

The Move Abroad Roadmap

Your step-by-step guide to starting your life in Madrid.

Written from experience. Not from a blog post someone else wrote.

1

DECIDE

2

RESEARCH

3

PAPERWORK

4

FINANCE

5

LOGISTICS

6

ARRIVE

Proof that it is never too late to choose yourself.

How to Use This Roadmap

This is not a listicle. It is not ten things you should probably think about someday. It is a phase-by-phase plan built around the actual sequence of what needs to happen when you are moving from the US to Madrid, written by someone who did it.

Work through it in order. Each phase builds on the last. Skipping ahead is how people end up with apostilled documents and no visa appointment, or a flight booked before they have confirmed their NIE process.

Phase	Focus	When to Start
1 – Decide	Clarity and commitment	12+ months out
2 – Research	Visa, money, neighborhoods	9–12 months out
3 – Paperwork	Documents, apostilles, applications	6–9 months out
4 – Finance	Banking, budget, money transfer setup	4–6 months out
5 – Logistics	Housing, healthcare, what to bring	1–3 months out
6 – Arrive	First 90 days on the ground in Madrid	After you land

Important:

A note on timelines: these are minimums, not targets. If you can give yourself more time, take it. The visa process alone has surprised people who thought they were organized. Start earlier than you think you need to.

PHASE 1 • 12+ MONTHS BEFORE YOU MOVE

Get Clear Before You Commit

The most expensive mistake people make is starting the paperwork before they have answered the real questions. This phase is about making a grounded decision, not just an excited one.

Answer these honestly before anything else

- Why Madrid specifically? Is it the city or the idea of the city? They are different. Visit for at least two weeks in a non-summer month before committing.
- What does your income look like? Spain's Non-Lucrative Visa requires proof of passive income. The Digital Nomad Visa requires active remote employment or freelance. Neither works if your finances do not fit the criteria.
- Do you have dependents, property, or obligations that complicate a move? Identify every anchor point now. Most are manageable. None of them disappear by ignoring them.
- Are you running toward something or away from something? Madrid will not fix a life you have not examined. It will, however, give you space to build one you actually want.

Do a reconnaissance trip

- Stay at least 10 to 14 days. Rent an apartment, not a hotel room.
- Live like a resident: buy groceries, take the metro, sit in the neighborhood you think you want to live in on a Tuesday morning.
- Visit in October, November, March, or April. Madrid in July is not Madrid the rest of the year.
- Pay attention to whether you feel at ease or just on vacation. Those are different feelings.

Madrid neighborhoods at a glance:

Neighborhoods worth exploring on your trip: Malasaña (creative, young, loud), Chueca (vibrant, LGBTQ+ friendly, walkable), Salamanca (polished, expensive, quieter), Lavapiés (multicultural, artsy, very local), Chamberí (residential, calm, popular with expats). Each one is a different city.

Decide on your visa category before you do anything else

- **Non-Lucrative Visa (NLV):** For people with passive income, pensions, savings, or investment returns. You cannot work in Spain on this visa. Requires approximately €27,800/year in income (2024 figure, verify annually) plus €6,900 per dependent.
- **Digital Nomad Visa:** For remote workers or freelancers whose clients or employer are primarily outside Spain. Requires a minimum income of €2,646/month (2024). Allows you to work remotely legally.
- **Entrepreneur Visa:** For people starting a business in Spain. Requires a business plan and approval from a government body. More complex.
- **Student Visa:** For people enrolling in a Spanish language school or accredited program. Not a path to residency on its own but used as an entry point by some.

If you are unsure which visa fits your situation, consult a Spanish immigration lawyer before starting any paperwork. A one-hour consultation costs far less than filing the wrong application.

PHASE 2 • 9–12 MONTHS BEFORE YOU MOVE

Research Like It Is Your Job

By this point you have chosen your visa category and done a reconnaissance trip. Now you build the knowledge base you will need to make every decision that follows.

Understand the real cost of living in Madrid

Expense	Estimated Monthly Range (EUR)	Notes
Rent (1-bed, central)	€1,100 – €1,800	Salamanca/Chueca higher
Rent (1-bed, outer barrios)	€800 – €1,200	Vallecas, Carabanchel
Groceries	€200 – €350	Mercadona is your friend
Dining out	€150 – €400	Menu del día €12–15
Transport (metro card)	€54.60	Monthly abono
Private health insurance	€50 – €200	Required for NLV
Utilities	€80 – €150	Electricity can spike in summer
Mobile phone	€15 – €30	Local SIM recommended
Leisure / Social	€100 – €300	Highly variable
TOTAL ESTIMATE	€1,950 – €3,480	Excluding rent: €850–1,680

Find a gestor

A gestor is a Spanish administrative professional who handles paperwork on your behalf. They are not a lawyer but they know the bureaucratic system inside out. For visa applications, residency renewals, and tax filings, a good gestor is not optional, it is the difference between your application being accepted and being returned for a missing stamp.

- Look for a gestor who works specifically with expats and English-speaking clients.
- Expect to pay €200 to €600 for visa application assistance depending on complexity.
- Ask in expat Facebook groups (Madrid Expats, Americans in Madrid) for personal recommendations.

Start building your Spain knowledge base

- Learn how the NIE (Número de Identificación de Extranjero) works. It is your foreign ID number and you will need it for almost everything.
- Understand empadronamiento: registering your address at the local town hall (ayuntamiento). Required for many services, including some visa renewals.

- Learn what Seguridad Social is and whether it applies to your visa category.
- Research the Spanish tax treaty with the US. If you are an American, you are still required to file US taxes. Spain has specific residency tax implications after 183 days. Speak to a US expat tax specialist, not just a general accountant.

PHASE 3 • 6–9 MONTHS BEFORE YOU MOVE

The Paperwork Phase

This phase is unglamorous, time-sensitive, and the one most people underestimate. Build your document package methodically. One missing item can delay your visa by months.

Core documents required for most Spain visas

Document	What You Need	Watch Out For
Valid US Passport	Valid for 1+ year beyond intended stay	Renew now if under 18 months remaining
FBI Background Check	Federal-level only. Apostilled.	Takes 3–6 weeks. Order early.
Proof of Income / Bank Statements	Last 3–6 months. Notarized if required.	Currency conversion may be needed
Private Health Insurance Certificate	Spain-approved provider. No copays, full coverage.	Sanitas, Adeslas, Asisa accepted
Proof of Accommodation	Rental contract or letter from host	Must be signed, dated, official
Passport Photos	Specific EU dimensions (35mm x 45mm)	Not US standard size. Get new ones.
Birth Certificate (some visas)	Apostilled official copy	Order from vital records early
Visa Application Form	Completed in Spanish or bilingual	Your gestor handles this

Understanding apostilles

An apostille is a form of authentication recognized by countries that have signed the Hague Convention, which includes Spain and the US. Many of your documents will need to be apostilled before Spain will accept them.

- Contact your Secretary of State office for state-issued documents (birth certificates, marriage certificates).
- The US Department of State handles apostilles for federal documents like FBI background checks.
- Allow 4 to 8 weeks. Expedited options exist but cost more.
- Once apostilled, documents typically need to be translated into Spanish by a certified translator. Your gestor can recommend one.

Critical scheduling note:

Apply for your visa appointment at the Spanish Consulate that covers your US state of residence. Not all consulates are equal in wait times. Some cities have 2-week waits, others have 3-month waits. Check appointment availability before you finalize your move date. The appointment date will anchor everything else in your timeline.

PHASE 4 • 4–6 MONTHS BEFORE YOU MOVE

Get Your Money Right

Financial setup is the phase people leave the latest and regret the most. Sort this before you sort anything else in logistics.

Build your relocation fund

- Target a minimum of 3 months of full living expenses in liquid savings before you leave, separate from any income you will have in Spain.
- Account for one-time arrival costs: first month rent, security deposit (usually 1–2 months), furniture if unfurnished, initial paperwork fees. Budget €3,000 to €6,000 for arrival costs alone.
- Keep a US emergency fund intact. Do not move everything to Spain. You need a financial cushion in both places for the first year.

Set up international money transfer

- **Wise (formerly TransferWise):** Best exchange rates for regular transfers. Open an account now and test a small transfer before you need it.
- **Revolut:** Good for day-to-day spending abroad. Pair with Wise for larger transfers.
- **Your US bank:** Keep it open. You will still need it for US taxes, Social Security, and family transactions.
- Avoid airport and hotel currency exchange. The rates are punitive.

Opening a Spanish bank account

You will likely need a Spanish bank account to pay rent, set up utilities, and interact with Spanish services. The challenge is that most Spanish banks require a NIE, which you may not have until after you arrive.

- **Before arrival:** Open a Wise or N26 account. Both are EU-based digital banks that do not require a NIE and give you a Euro IBAN.
- **After arrival:** Open an account at Santander, BBVA, or CaixaBank. Santander has English-speaking staff in many Madrid branches.
- Some banks will open an account for non-residents with your passport only. Ask specifically for a *cuenta de no residente* if you arrive before your residency is confirmed.

Understand your tax situation now, not later

- As a US citizen you must file US federal taxes regardless of where you live. The Foreign Earned Income Exclusion (FEIE) may apply depending on your income type.
- Spain considers you a tax resident after 183 days in the country per calendar year. Once a tax resident, you are subject to Spanish income tax on worldwide income.
- FBAR filing is required if you hold more than \$10,000 in foreign accounts at any point during the year. This is a separate form from your tax return.
- Hire a US expat tax specialist before your first year ends. This is not something to figure out after the fact.

PHASE 5 • 1–3 MONTHS BEFORE YOU MOVE

The Logistics Phase

By now your visa is in process or approved. This phase is about the practical execution of actually leaving and being ready when you land.

Finding housing in Madrid before you arrive

- Do not sign a long-term lease before you have spent time in the neighborhood. Book an Airbnb or short-term furnished rental for your first 4 to 8 weeks.
- Use the first weeks to apartment hunt in person. The best rentals in Madrid are found on Idealista and Fotocasa, not through international relocation agencies.
- Landlords will typically ask for: NIE, proof of income, and sometimes a Spanish guarantor or extra deposit. Budget 1 to 2 months deposit.
- Furnished apartments cost more but save you thousands in furniture. For a first-year move, furnished is almost always the right call.

What to bring, ship, or let go

- **Bring:** Documents (physical copies of everything), laptop, medications (with prescriptions), sentimental items that cannot be replaced, quality clothing you know fits your life there.
- **Ship only if it makes financial sense:** International shipping is expensive. Price it honestly. A sofa that costs €400 in Madrid may not be worth \$800 in shipping from the US.
- **Sell or store:** Large furniture, cars, US-specific appliances (voltage differences matter), anything you are keeping out of guilt.
- **Electronics:** Spain uses 220V / 50Hz. US appliances run on 110V / 60Hz. A converter works for some items but damages others. Research each device.

Health insurance for the visa and beyond

- The Non-Lucrative Visa requires private health insurance with no copays and coverage in Spain for the full visa period. Confirm your plan is on the approved list before you buy it.
- Providers commonly accepted: Sanitas, Adeslas, Asisa, DKV. Compare plans. A basic plan starts around €50 to €80/month for a healthy adult.
- Once you become a legal resident and register with Social Security (if applicable to your visa), you may gain access to the Spanish public healthcare system. This does not replace private insurance for the NLV.

Before you leave the US

- Notify your US bank and credit cards of your move.
- Set up a mail forwarding service (US Global Mail, Traveling Mailbox).
- Handle any US-based financial accounts, insurance, or subscriptions.

- Bring 3 to 6 months of any prescription medications. Confirm each is legal to bring into Spain.
- Carry all visa documents and critical paperwork in your carry-on. Never checked luggage.

PHASE 6 • YOUR FIRST 90 DAYS IN MADRID

Land, Register, and Settle

You are here. This phase is about getting the administrative foundation in place so that everything else, the life part, can actually begin.

Week 1 to 2: The immediate priorities

- Get a local SIM card immediately. Movistar, Vodafone, and Orange all have English support. A local number is required for almost every form you will fill out.
- Open a Spanish bank account if you have not done so already.
- Register with your nearest ayuntamiento (town hall) to get your *empadronamiento*. You need a rental contract or letter from your landlord. This certificate is required for many subsequent steps.
- Book your TIE appointment (Tarjeta de Identidad de Extranjero) as soon as possible. This is your physical residency card. Appointments can be weeks out.

Month 1: Getting set up properly

- Confirm your NIE is active and your TIE appointment is scheduled.
- Register with a local doctor (médico de cabecera) if you have access to the public health system. If not, identify your private clinic and GP.
- Set up utilities in your name if you are in a long-term rental.
- Get a transport abono (monthly metro card). The Zone A abono covers all of central Madrid for €54.60/month.

The stuff nobody warns you about

- Bureaucracy moves slowly and on its own schedule. Bring snacks, a book, and your patience to every appointment.
- Everything closes between roughly 2pm and 5pm. Plan your errands around this.
- Dinner is at 9pm or later. If you eat at 6pm you will be dining alone.
- Most Madrilenos do not speak much English outside of tourist areas. Basic Spanish goes a very long way and is received with genuine warmth.
- The first 60 days can feel bureaucratic, lonely, and overwhelming simultaneously. This is normal. It passes. Build in one enjoyable thing every single day regardless of what else is happening.

Community:

Finding your people: Madrid has a strong expat community. Facebook groups (Americans in Madrid, Madrid Expats, Women in Madrid) are active and genuinely helpful. Meetup.com has regular English-language social events. Language exchange events (intercambios) are one of the best ways to meet locals. Give it 90 days before you decide whether you have found your footing.

Master Checklist

Print this page. Check things off as you complete them. This is the only checklist you need.

Phase 1: Decide (12+ months out)

- Take a reconnaissance trip to Madrid (min. 10 days)
- Confirm visa category based on your income situation
- Consult an immigration lawyer or gestor for your specific case
- Assess all US obligations: property, dependents, accounts
- Make the decision with clear eyes

Phase 2: Research (9–12 months out)

- Research Madrid neighborhoods and shortlist 2 to 3
- Find a recommended gestor who works with expats
- Research US expat tax implications and find a specialist
- Study real Madrid cost of living numbers, not blog estimates
- Join 2 to 3 Madrid expat online communities

Phase 3: Paperwork (6–9 months out)

- Order FBI background check
- Request and apostille all required documents
- Renew passport if needed
- Purchase Spain-approved private health insurance
- Book Spanish Consulate visa appointment
- Submit visa application with gestor support

Phase 4: Finance (4–6 months out)

- Open Wise account and test an international transfer
- Build 3-month liquid relocation fund
- Estimate one-time arrival costs and budget for them
- Brief US expat tax specialist on your situation
- Set up mail forwarding service

Phase 5: Logistics (1–3 months out)

- Book short-term furnished accommodation for first 4–8 weeks
- Decide what to bring, ship, sell, or store

- Bring 3 to 6 months of prescription medications
- Notify US bank and credit cards of move
- Handle US subscriptions and accounts
- Pack all documents in carry-on bag

Phase 6: First 90 Days

- Buy local SIM card on arrival
- Register at ayuntamiento for empadronamiento
- Open Spanish bank account
- Book TIE appointment
- Register with local doctor or identify private clinic
- Get monthly metro abono
- Find one enjoyable thing every day for the first 60 days

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